

Blu-ray sales

Blu-ray sales in the US increased by 91 per cent in the first half of 2009 despite the global recession

100GB disks

Sharp Japan has developed an improved Blu-ray disk with a capacity of 75GB and 100GB

Feature

Launched in India in April 2007, the Playstation 3 is the crown jewel in Sony's Blu-ray lineup. Sony took the risk of including a Blu-ray drive in the console by default. As a result, the PS3 is now the largest selling Blu-ray player in the market, whether explicitly purchased for this purpose or not. The PS3 supports multiple file formats including DivX, supports wireless media streaming from your PC and enables 7.1 HD audio over HDMI.

The fact that it doubles as a next generation game console and has support for internet browsing works in its favour as well. The only negatives one can think of are the lack of 7.1 analogue sound support as well as the region lock on the console. The PS3 is priced at Rs.



Sony's PS3 is the largest selling Blu-ray player

20,000 for the 80 GB version while stocks of the older 40 GB version are being sold at Rs. 15,000.

Finally, which player should you buy? It really comes down to whether you plan to play games on the PS3 or not. For purists, assembling a home theatre set-up, a standalone player might make more sense, providing more features/options in the audio department. For everyone else, the PS3 is a value for money player, if you really want to buy a Blu-ray device. In fact, you'd prefer the newer 120GB PS3 'Slim'. While it will be priced at the same Rs. 20,000 price as the current 80 GB model, it will not have any games bundled along with it.

Sales trends

Several large multi-brand electronic stores we visited either did not stock Blu-ray players or had only one or two models in stock. The saving grace for Blu-ray

is that the PS3 is ubiquitous at almost every store that you visit.

While Sony and other manufacturers have not released any sales numbers for Blu-ray player/PS3 sales in India, many store managers we talked to confirmed that they haven't seen any major push from manufacturers, or demand for Blu-ray players from consumers. While the recent price cut of the PS3 from Rs. 25,000 to Rs. 20,000 was expected to boost demand, sales stayed relatively flat even during the recent festival season, trailing the XBOX 360 at most places. Only one of the store managers we talked to was optimistic about sales of standalone Blu-ray players, with his store selling around seven players a month.

Pricing of media is a factor that needs to be kept in mind when we look at the availability and sales of Blu-ray media. Games for the PS3 in the Blu-ray format are priced in the Rs. 1,500 to Rs. 2,500 range, Hindi movies are typically priced at Rs. 1,000, and most English movies range from Rs. 1,300 to Rs. 1,500 depending on the popularity of the movie. Compared to this, Hindi DVDs for popular releases are available from Rs. 99, while English movies cost a maximum of Rs. 500. While manufacturers may talk about targeting quality conscious buyers until prices of Blu-ray media come down to more reasonable levels, a majority of Indian consumers will be hesitant to invest in the format even if they are considering the switch to HD.

As with any new technology, Blu-ray players are quite expensive. While prices of Blu-ray players have come down since they were initially launched. For example, from \$1,500 to under \$150 in certain cases, manufacturers hope to bring down prices even more with experience and technological advances in the future. Unfortunately, pricing of Blu-ray players in India is still quite high and this is not conducive to the acceptance of the format.

By the way, the only reason a next generation console like the PS3 can incorporate Blu-ray playback and still cost the same as other regular Blu-ray players is

DEMYSTIFYING REGION CODES

Blu-ray discs sold in a particular region are also supposed to be played only in that region. For example, a Blu-ray player purchased in the United States may not play certain discs, no matter how hard you try.

For Hindi movies, discs from Sony and Big Home Video are region free while those from Excel Home Video are coded to Region C (India). Out of the major English movie studios, releases by Paramount, Universal, Sony and Warner are region free. Titles released by Lionsgate Films and Walt Disney are a mix of both while those released by 20th Century Fox are region coded.

Depending on the model of your player and its firmware version, you may be able to find instructions online on how to change its region or make it region free to play all discs.

because Sony subsidises the hardware cost of the PS3 platform. Like most console manufacturers, Sony expects to recover its costs through sales of accessories and royalties from game developers.

While digital downloads for movies haven't really taken off in India yet, companies such as Bigflix have started experimenting with online models allowing users to download movies of their choice to buy or rent for a certain time period. Though currently restricted to DVD quality content, these companies can move into the high definition content space in the future. All they need is a more robust broadband infrastructure. In case such services catch on, it may not even make sense for consumers to invest in an expensive high definition Blu-ray player when they can just hook up a laptop or LCD TV and stream a movie off the internet. With so much money invested in the Blu-ray format, companies like Sony need to do all they can to increase awareness and adoption of Blu-ray in the Indian market.

Looking at the challenges posed by online content over the long term, Blu-ray may actually never turn out to be comparable to the blockbuster that DVD was. If they want adoption of the Blu-ray format to take-off in the Indian market, manufacturers will have to look at providing both hardware as well as content at a lower price. Only then will a large chunk of customers find it worthwhile to shift to high definition content. 